



Office-in-waiting MS Office 2003

Microsoft is making available the 2nd Beta version of the next Office to all comers. Take a look at what's on offer.

In practice, Microsoft releases a new version of its Office suite every two years. This time, it has condensed the gap, giving users less time to decide whether to upgrade or not. This is due to fine competition from opponents such as Sun, which performs well with its StarOffice and small time developers. Dubbed as Office 11, this upgraded version has got a few added features to its name such as OneNote for E-note making (for Tablet PC users) and Info Path to create XML documents.

It has also come up with its Business Contact Manager—an Outlook add-on—to help sort contact databases. An added feature called the Rights Management Service helps users protect files and e-mails.

The new SharePoint Team Services 2.0 (which works only with the new Windows Server 2003, Internet Information Services 6.0 and SQL Server) features a document workspace where employees share documents with co-workers. SharePoint also offers a new Meetings workspace for conducting online presentations, sharing meeting minutes and action items, and managing all materials and follow-up actions.

All in all, Microsoft has focussed more on ease of use in most applications and some of them have been awarded with a lot of new features. To an individual user, there may not be major compelling reasons to upgrade from first looks, but for an enterprise environment with long document lifetimes, XML integration and beefed up collaborating features are very serious reasons to take a look.



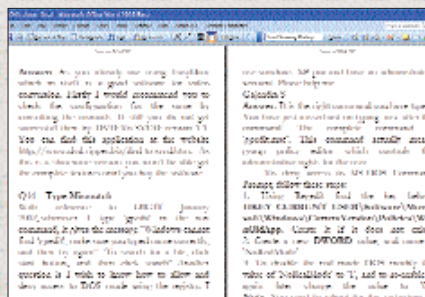
Style and formatting restrictions: With Word 2003, you can use the Style Lockdown feature that disables direct formatting. This allows complex documents to be edited by many people while retaining structured formatting.



Formatting restrictions

Range Permissions: Range Permissions allow portions of a document to be protected against editing by some or all users. Hence you can first protect the whole document against any edits, then assign permissions to individual portions of the document by selecting them and choosing which users should be able to edit that selected area.

New reading mode: The new Reading Layout makes it easier to read documents

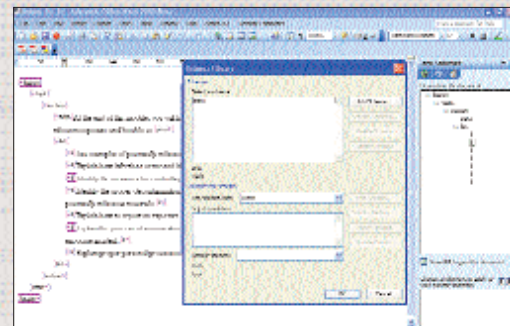


The new reading mode makes on screen reading easier

on screen. The text is displayed with clean margins, shorter lines, a larger font and space permitting two pages per screen. This makes on-screen documents easier to read.

Write inside of Word comments: Word provides an ink comment bubble feature, which allows you to ink inside of Word comments with all of the same features, such as the ability to filter by the author. Using Comment bubbles ensures that the annotations will remain anchored to the text that was commented on as the document is edited later on. **Two ink modes:** In addition to annotating directly on the document surface, users can insert hand-drawings in Word through the same interface as pictures or text boxes. You are given a canvas inside the document for their sketches, which acts like an ink picture. Double-clicking on the ink image produces a format ink dialog box, in the same way as a text box or picture, with options to wrap text around the ink, resize the canvas, etc. **Thumbnail view:** Apart from the usual views provided, an all-new thumbnail view; very similar to the thumbnail view in Adobe Acrobat Reader, has been provided for easy navigation in large documents. **Thesaurus:** Word 2003 now includes a thesaurus via the Research task pane, for those times when you are looking for just the right word.

XML in Word 2003: Word 2003 allows documents to be saved in XML and supports the creation of templates based on customer-defined schemas. You can choose to save just the data or round-trip with full formatting preservation.



User-defined XML schemas structure documents